

Plate 5.14 Low Quality Food Grade Plastic

Other adulterants

Pests such as rats, rodents and insects introduce into the food a high degree of filth in the form of excreta, bodily secretions and spoilage microorganisms. Chemicals like DDT are absorbed by the small intestine when ingested. The toxins usually pile up in the fatty tissues of such vital organs as the thyroid, heart, kidney, liver, mammary gland and damage these organs.

This incidental poisoning can be prevented by:

- Regular market surveys to warn people on the dangerous build-up of toxins in food.
- Stepping up the integrated pest management programme to teach farmers to use pesticides judiciously. No spraying should be done a week before harvest.
- Using safer pesticides
- Washing vegetables thoroughly before cooking.

Prevention of Food Adulteration Act (PFA 1954)

Keeping the large scale adulteration in view, legislation was passed called Prevention of Food Adulteration Act in the year 1954 with the objectives to

- Ensure pure and wholesome food to the consumers and also to prevent fraud or deception.
- Protect the public from poisonous and harmful food.
- Prevent the sale of substandard foods.
- Protect the interests of the consumers by eliminating fraudulent practices.

Food additives

Food additives have been used for centuries to enhance the appearance and flavour of food and prolong shelf life. Food additives find their way into the foods to help ease processing, packaging, and storage. Some additives have been used for centuries; for example, preserving food by pickling as with vinegar, salting, as with bacon, preserving sweets or using sulphur dioxide as with wines.

DO YOU KNOW?

Food Additive

A food additive is a substance added to food to enhance its flavour or appearance or to preserve it

Artificial Sweeteners

Aspartame is found in foods labelled "diet" or "sugar-free". Aspartame is believed to be carcinogenic, neurotoxin and accounts for more reports of adverse reactions than all other foods and food additives combined.